



EFY Awards 2009 Have Been Postponed

EFY Awards were originally scheduled to be held on the 16th of March at New Delhi's India Habitat Centre. But owing to the current tumultuous situation of the industry, we have postponed the Awards so that we don't end up throwing a party when our peers are facing challenging times.

New dates and venue for EFY Awards 2009 will be announced shortly.



management levels in sales and marketing functions. Given the present economic scenario, firms have an acute focus on conceiving new business as well as capitalising on every possible sales opportunity. The highest paid job function in an organisation, once again, has corresponded with this new focus. Forty-one per cent of companies reported sales and marketing as the highest paid function in their organisations, compared to 24 per cent last year (fiscal 2007-08)—a huge increase of 17 per cent.

Furthermore, new-age employers prefer to perceive prospective employees as complete packages, endowed with more than just one specific skill. Even the requirements of a technical job can no longer be satisfied solely by technical competencies; economic and business process knowledge as well as requisite soft skills are heralded as cardinal. Knowledge of enterprise resource planning (ERP) systems, particularly in the field of sales automation, is deemed 'nice-to-have.'

Surely, companies worldwide are also looking for innovative products as well as new business models to establish a niche for themselves amidst the competitive clutter. In this context, research and development (R&D) is turning out to be a key area where skilled professionals are getting rewarded now more than ever. This is confirmed by Mr Basavaraj, managing director of Neural Systems, when he says, "In a nutshell, it is an ideal situation to invest in long-term plans emphasising on R&D and IP with adequate, talented manpower." This fiscal, 33 per cent of the respondents identified R&D as their highest paying function, which is 9 per cent higher than last year.

Among the sub-segments of the electronics industry, telecom is showing the maximum promise of growth. It doesn't come as a surprise therefore that R&D and business development activities in this sector offer the highest pay packets for almost all levels of employees.

Training could be the key

A lull across the salary front could spell out an opportunity elsewhere. According to 98 per cent of the respondents, improvement in staff training is a valuable way of proofing their businesses for the future. In fact, roughly 78 per cent of the surveyed firms provided paid trainings across all levels to improve internal efficiencies and processes, which is quite promising in comparison with the 38 per cent figure for 2007-08.

Apart from the usual expectations pertaining to remuneration, there is also the demand in some quarters, especially from the design engineers, for a flexible work environment. Presently, two-thirds (67 per cent) of the firms surveyed, supported alternative work schedules or flexible timings, along with compressed hours of the week—work for the same number of hours in lesser number of days. Last year, the figure was 58 per cent. It clearly indicates that flexibility is a major strategy of the firms to retain key talent.

The scenario may not be so cooperative in matters like paternity leave. Though the proportion of firms (63 per cent) allowing paternity leave was higher than last year (50 per cent), companies seemed to be getting stringent about the number of days leave is granted for. None of the firms allowed more than one month of leave, with more firms (12 per cent higher than 2007-08) stipulating around 15 days only.

To sum up, the electronics industry in India appears to be marching right ahead, unfazed by the turmoil around it. While talented individuals in other sectors may be struggling to find stepping stones in times when lay-offs and hiring freezes are the order of the day, the employees in the Indian electronics industry have more than a bright chance to override the recession and kickstart their careers in this industry. ●

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